it's almost like it's the 21st century

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64576573.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Friends to Lovers, Mutual Pining, Pining Adora (She-Ra), Pining Catra (She-Ra), Banter, Sharing a Bed, Fluff, Hurt/Comfort, But just a little, Homophobia, this is not homophobia centric i promise, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-04-10 Completed: 2025-05-19 Words: 15,438 Chapters: 5/5

it's almost like it's the 21st century

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64576573.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Friends to Lovers, Mutual Pining, Pining Adora (She-Ra), Pining Catra (She-Ra), Banter, Sharing a Bed, Fluff, Hurt/Comfort, But just a little, Homophobia, this is not homophobia centric i promise, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-04-10 Completed: 2025-05-19 Words: 15,438 Chapters: 5/5

it's almost like it's the 21st century

by k8 a

Summary

Adora’s parents are coming into town. It should be fine…

If it wasn’t for their continued denial of Adora’s sexuality that she’s starting to get so sick of. If it wasn’t for the business that Adora is supposed to inherit.
“You’re just confused, Adora.”
“It’ll all change when you find the right man.”
“Adora, think about the business.”
This time, Adora is determined to change their minds by introducing them to her girlfriend. The only problem? She doesn’t actually have a girlfriend.

**This fic contains some homophobia in chapters one and two, and brief internalized homophobia in Chapter One. It also contains Gay As Shit Adora and even, if you can believe it, Gay As Shit Catra, too.

**** the last chapter of this fic was never fully written, it's in there as a bullet point outline. i wanted you guys to know how it ends, but life caught up with me and i won't be able to fully finish this for at least a few months :')

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Everyone expects it by now, but that doesn't stop Adora from sprinting.

Feet pounding the pavement, breath coming in short gasps. This time, she's been forced to leave her car almost a mile away. The night air cools her burning lungs as she nears Bow's apartment. Catra's motorcycle sits on the curb, and Adora only hates her a little for how easily she always scores the closest parking spot. She flies up the stairs, barely even slowing as she throws the door open.

Without sparing Adora a glance, Glimmer checks her phone, then calls into the kitchen, "Twenty seven minutes. Bow, you owe me five bucks!"

Bow groans from the kitchen. "Come on, Adora. You couldn't have held off three more minutes? I wanted to buy the fancy ice cream with that money!"

"There's no parking around your goddamn apartment, Bow. What the fuck. I parked a mile away! And ran! For no appreciation!" Adora puts her hands on her knees, still trying to catch her breath.

"Is that why you're so sweaty?" Catra appears from the kitchen with two wine glasses and a smirk. "Wine?"

Something crashes in the kitchen. "No wine until she gets her ass in here!"

Catra and Adora exchange a thoughtful look. Then, Catra offers the glass, and Adora downs half the glass in one gulp.

"I saw that," Bow complains.

"Shut up. I need this." Adora kicks her shoes off. "My mom called today."

Glimmer immediately perks up from the couch. She's always loved other people's gossip. "I haven't heard about your mom in ages!"

"That makes four of us." Adora walks into the kitchen. Bow stands in front of the stove in the middle of a warzone. Three pots simmer on the stove, red sauce splatters the front of Bow's shirt, and a few half butchered vegetables sit abandoned on a plastic cutting board. The sink is still running, overflowing a sauce-stained pot. "Jesus, what happened?"

Bow pouts, aggressively stirring a pot of bubbling red sauce. "I wanted to try something new, but *someone* took too long to show up."

"You could've… I don't know… waited?"

"I've never been a patient man."

Glimmer snorts from her spot on the couch. "That's a fucking lie. But *I* am not a patient man. What did your mom say?"

Immediately, Adora's mood sours again. "Her and dad are coming into town." She busies herself with clearing abandoned dishes off the counter until Bow directs her at the lonely vegetables on the cutting board.

“Isn’t that a good thing?” Catra leans on the counter between the kitchen and the living room, scrutinizing the chaos in the kitchen.

Adora takes her tension out on the onion, and keenly ignores the amusement in Catra’s eyes. “I haven’t seen them in a while. But, every time they come in, they try to set me up with some hotshot rich guy.”

“They really struggle with the concept of ‘lesbian,’ huh?” Glimmer accentuates the word with an extravagant wave of her hand.

“It’s obnoxious.”

Bow stirs the sauce with one hand and pokes a spatula into the sizzling beef with the other. “Do you think your parents can set me up with a hot rich guy?”

Adora and Catra exchange a glance. They’ve both suffered through almost a year of Bow and Glimmer’s ridiculous pining. It’s gotten to the point of absolute irritation. Adora and Catra have beared witness to every gooey-eyed gaze, every drawn out conversation about how sweet Bow is or how endearing Glimmer’s feistiness can be. Every missed opportunity between the friends. When asked, they both make excuses about ruining friendships or making the vibe of the group weird.

Glimmer swirls the wine around her glass and laughs. “Sign me up, too.”

“If you guys want to suffer through this dinner instead of me, that’s great for you.” Adora bumps Bow out of her way with her hip and scrapes the onion into the beef pan.

“Oof. On second thought…”

Adora frowns at the beef and takes the sauce spoon from Bow’s hand as he moves away. They’re a well-oiled machine in the kitchen. They never use recipes. Somehow, Bow’s love of experimentation perfectly complements Adora’s skill, and they’ve created some great things over the years. Back in college, they

implemented Friday Night Dinners. Adora and Bow would try some new foods while Glimmer and Catra sit on the couch, drink wine, and talk shit. They're the perfect guinea pigs for the meals. Brutally honest, but still willing to eat whatever ends up on a plate in front of them.

Glimmer gasps. "Guys! New client alert!"

"Oh my god oh my god oh my god-" Bow almost trips on his way out of the kitchen. "Show me show me show me!"

Adora leans over the counter as Glimmer holds up her phone to show off a picture of the crustiest white dog in the entire wide world.

Glimmer and Bow both run the Bright Moon Dog Daycare full time. Glimmer's mother launched the business years ago, but she spends too much time traveling with Glimmer's dad now to manage the business. Glimmer had jumped on the opportunity to take on daycare, which is pretty ideal for Adora. One of her favorite hobbies is visiting Glimmer at work. A huge destresser after her longer days at university.

Glimmer thrusts her phone at Catra, who takes a mild glance at the dog and mumbles some sort of acknowledgement. Catra's never been a dog person, but she at least tries to indulge the three of them when a new client appears at Bright Moon.

No one said her best is very good.

"Something smells," Catra comments around a sip of wine.

Bow and Adora spring up at the same time, and Bow almost takes them both down in their hurry back to the stove.

Minutes later, Adora finally plops down into her seat at the table, satisfied with the set up she and Bow pulled off tonight.

"More wine?" Catra asks, topping off her own glass.

“Please. I’m gonna need it if my mom is coming into town.” Adora takes the first bite of her pasta and nods appreciatively at her own work.

Glimmer holds out her wine glass, too. “Why don’t you just tell her you’re not into guys?”

“I have, that’s the problem! She thinks I’m just being edgy and temporary. So she tries to hook me up with all these random guys, and when I don’t hit it off and immediately have his babies, she gets mad and brings up all this stuff about-” Adora puts on her best pretentious tone “-the face of the company, and the future of our assets, and she’s supporting me in everything, and I should just settle, and blah blah blah.” Adora stabs her fork into her pasta.

“Okay. I hate to be the bad guy. But why not go along with it when she’s here?” That earns Bow three hard glares. “Only temporarily! Like, she’s putting you through college and paying for your apartment. You’re the epitome of Daddy’s Money.”

“Mom’s money,” Adora grumbles. “And I know she’s doing a lot, but it’s not like she even notices it in her bank account. She could put sixteen Adoras through college and buy all of them houses and her bank wouldn’t even blink.”

“That’s kind of my point. That’s going to be you when you take over her company. Why not appease her while she’s here?”

Adora takes a long sip of wine and exhales deeply. “I don’t want to disappoint her, but that doesn’t mean I’m going to put on some sort of act either. I wish I could just… prove it to her.”

“Why not bring your girlfriend?” Glimmer asks.

“Thanks for rubbing my singleness in my face, Glimmer.”

“I’m serious. Just have someone pretend for the weekend. They can’t try to hook you up with some guy if you’re already hooking up with some girl.”

Adora stares at the ceiling, absorbing the idea. “That’s…” She perks up suddenly, grinning. “Genius! Why didn’t I think of that?”

“I charge forty bucks per hour for my ideas.”

“So you’ll be my girlfriend, and-”

“Ha!” Glimmer practically barks, and violently shakes her head. “I am not kissing you.”

“Come on, Glimmer! Just for a few days.”

Glimmer crosses her arms and shakes her head even harder. “No fucking way.”

“I can cross dress,” Bow offers.

“Honey,” Glimmer starts, and Adora doesn’t miss how Bow’s cheeks redden a little. “With all my love and respect, you could not pull it off.”

“Hey! I take that personally-”

“Catra,” Adora turns to Catra, who’s stayed quiet through this entire conversation.

“No.”

“Please?”

“No.”

“Please?” Adora puts on her best puppy eyes.

Seconds pass where Catra, arms crossed and face stern, analyzes Adora. Glimmer and Bow mutter to each other, but Adora stays focused on looking desperate and sad. She laces her fingers together on her lap and hunches her shoulders. “Please.”

“What am I getting out of this?” Catra asks apprehensively.

She’s gaining traction. “I’ll make you dinner for a week.”

“You already do that once a week anyway.”

“Not every day, though!”

“Not good enough.”

“You gain my everlasting respect and humility?”

“*Definitely* not good enough.”

“Dinner, twice a week, for an entire month, and I’ll wash your motorcycle.”

“Fine.”

Adora blinks. This feels a little too easy. But, Catra looks smug, like she’s the one who won here.

“You understand what this means, right? Like, dinner with my family?”

“Don’t try to talk me out of it. I know what I’m signing up for, and I know what *you’re* signing up for.” Catra sips her wine, elbow on the table as she leans toward Adora. “I cannot *wait* for you to be my personal chef.”

~~~~
~~~~

Adora stalks past Catra again, hand on her forehead, muttering to herself. Catra rolls her eyes and keeps scrolling through her phone for the next few passes.

When Adora reappears for the seventh time with a large vase in her hands, Catra finally lets her phone drop onto the couch. "Adora."

"No time," she responds and disappears into her bedroom.

Catra leans back on the couch and waits until Adora leaves the bedroom. When she tries to walk by again, Catra snatches her wrist in a firm grip. "Adora."

"What?" Adora finally stops long enough to meet Catra's gaze with a frazzled expression. Hair from her ponytail sticks out in all directions, and Catra's pretty sure her shirt is inside out.

"You need to chill."

"I can't just chill, Catra." Adora tries to pull her wrist away, but Catra tightens her hold. "Mom will be here any second, and my apartment is- and my room is-"

"And your hair," Catra tacks on, a smirk forming on her lips.

Adora's free hand darts up to her hair and her eyes widen again.

With a huff, Catra stands. "Your apartment is literally spotless. And, they won't be here for another hour. Go fix your hair, and

maybe change your shirt?”

At that, Adora’s chin drops to her definitely inside out shirt and her shoulders droop.

“Dude, it’s just your parents. They’re going to be exhausted anyway. They’re just going to come inside and pass out. You can worry about what they think tomorrow.”

“What *are* they gonna think?” Adora frowns and tugs at the bottom of her shirt. “Maybe this was a bad idea.”

“Having your parents over?”

“Having a *girlfriend* over.”

Catra turns that thought over in her mind. Adora’s made up such an elaborate story for the two of them. Down to specifying how they got together, where they went on their first date, how long Catra’s been living with her.

That’s the frosting on the cake. To be really convincing, Catra will be staying over for the time that Adora’s parents are here. A part of Catra wonders if it’s just Adora wanting some emotional support. Whatever, Catra can do that. Anything to taste some of Adora’s cooking for free.

Well…

Maybe it’s more selfish than that. It’s only been a few months since Catra started noticing. Noticing the way she gravitates toward Adora. The way that when they stand side by side, she feels at home. Noticing how when Adora laughs, she can’t look away. Catra knows that if she acknowledges it at all, she’ll be in over her head. But, she also knows that after enough time passes, whatever feelings she has for her best friend will fade away. So, she ignores it.

“I know it’s… complicated,” Catra starts lamely. She’s never been very good at the soothing part of things. “But they’re your

parents, and they love you. And they want what's best for you. And they'll see that you're… happy… and stuff."

"Happy with you?" Adora jokes half-heartedly.

"I'm a great fake girlfriend!"

Adora finally laughs, and some of the tension leaves her shoulders. "That's still up for debate."

"Hey, I'm doing the whole comforting thing right now, aren't I?"

"Right…" Adora tries and fails to smother a teasing smirk.

Catra huffs and drops Adora's wrist. "I'm trying."

"Right," she repeats dryly.

"Ugh. Go get dressed. You look like shit."

Adora laughs as she walks away. "So comforting."

True to Catra's word, it takes an hour before there's a solid knock at the door. Adora exchanges one worried glance with Catra before she opens it.

Immediately, Adora's dad envelopes her in a crushing hug. He's a thick man, as tall as Adora herself, with graying hair peeking out from underneath a golf club hat. It's Adora's mother that intimidates Catra. She towers over both Adora and her father. Her blonde hair is pulled back into a tight bun, and even after a day on an airplane, her obviously tailored shirt and slacks are spotless and unwrinkled. She looks straight past Adora and her father, still exchanging hugs and babbled greetings, to scrutinize the apartment. Then, her eyes fall on Catra.

"Adora, who is this?" Her mother asks as a greeting, a tight smile decorating her lips, though Catra still feels like she's being examined.

Adora practically jumps away from her father and slides to Catra's side to scoop up her hand in a too-tight grip. "This is Catra!"

Seconds pass as her mother's eyes drop to their joined hands, and her smile tightens further.

"She's my girlfriend," Adora adds after the silence.

Both of Adora's parents seem to be waiting. Waiting for Adora to say she's joking, maybe. After far too long, Catra clears her throat and pastes on some semblance of a smile.

"Catra," she introduces herself, and offers her free hand to Adora's mother.

"Charmed," Adora's mother shakes her hand with a vice-like grip, mirroring Adora's hold on her other hand. "Marlene. And this is Randall."

Catra shakes Randall's hand quickly. The portly man looks paler now. Honestly, from the description of Adora's parents, Catra expected them to be intimidating, but she didn't prepare herself for this level of tension.

"How long have the two of you…?" Marlene trails off, the smile on her face looking almost painful now.

“Almost a year now,” Adora answers a little too quickly. “Our anniversary is next month!”

Randall frowns. “You didn’t tell us over the phone.”

Somehow, Adora’s grip on Catra’s hand tightens even more. “You never asked.”

“We asked about men-” Randall starts, and anger edges into his voice.

Marlene holds up a hand. “Not tonight. I’m sure we’re all tired. The flight was very long, wasn’t it, sweetie?”

“Of course.” Randall still looks angry. “Long flight. I need to get off my feet.”

“Your room is this way.” Adora finally lets go of Catra’s hand to lead her parents down the hall.

The moment Adora closes the bedroom door, she drops her head against it and groans. Catra is already sitting cross-legged on the bed, waiting expectantly.

“That went well,” Catra says dryly, and Adora squeezes her eyes shut.

“Better than expected, honestly.”

“Really? I was joking.”

“I don’t want to talk about it.” Adora pushes off the wall. “I’m getting ready for bed.”

With that, she marches into the bathroom. Maybe she spends a little too long getting ready, dragging out the process of her skincare routine and brushing her teeth. But, eventually, she runs out of diversions and opens the door to the bedroom with a bracing sigh.

Catra looks up at her curiously. She’s still sitting in the same spot on the bed, legs crossed and a hand propping up her cheek. “Nice pajamas,” she says, and Adora catches the ghost of a smile on her face that looks almost fond.

Looking down at her holey band t-shirt that’s too faded to even read, Adora shrugs. “It’s comfy. Scoot.” She gets all up in Catra’s space and prods at her shoulder and side until she finally moves off the yellow duvet with a laugh. Adora flips the light switch off and just stands there, waiting.

Voices rise from the other room. Muffled arguing. They don’t seem to worry about anyone else in the apartment hearing them. “There we go, I was waiting for that.” She slides under the covers and holds the other side open for Catra.

Marlene’s voice rises over Randall’s, and Adora hears a few distinct words she wishes she didn’t before Catra moves, joining her under the covers. “I didn’t realize it was like this,” Catra says, words quiet and slow.

“It’s not their fault.” Adora immediately jumps to defend them, like she has since the first time she tried to come out. “It’s just their

generation, and the company atmosphere, and all that. They're just… traditional."

"You're their *daughter."*

"They didn't sign up for a gay daughter."

"Adora." Catra sits upright so fast Adora worries she'll fall off the bed. She's looking down at Adora with wide eyes and a frown that she can see even in the darkness. "That's a horrible way to think about this."

"I really don't want to talk about it." Adora resolutely turns on her side, away from Catra, and squeezes her eyes shut.

Silence falls in the room, but it takes a few extra moments before Catra settles back down in the bed next to her. The voices in the other room have gone silent.

"I'm gonna be the best goddamn girlfriend ever," Catra whispers, then pokes Adora's shoulder. "I'm gonna charm the shit out of your parents."

Adora can't help but laugh, pulling the covers up to her mouth. "You're stupid."

"I'm serious. They don't get a choice. They're *going* to like me."

Adora muffles her laugh with her blanket. "I'm going to bed. Goodnight."

"Goodnight, *babe."*

Chapter End Notes

deviating from voltron fic?????? couldn't be me

pov: i didn't write at all for far too long and i tried to write out a scene as a practice but now it's six chapters of adora and catra being in love

oops
also just fyi the next chapter contains a fight about homophobia and the rest of the fic is generally fluffy and sweet

most of this fic is finished so i'll be posting chapters relatively quickly, chapter three will post on monday!

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora looks perfect.

She's wearing the dress she bought for Glimmer's graduation party. The one that's classy, high-necked, and hugs her curves in all the right places. There isn't a hair out of place in her expertly braided fancy bun that Catra could never even try to pull off. And she's done her makeup - a rare sight - with simple eyeshadow that makes her blue eyes pop. She looks great.

So, Catra just leans up against the wall and examines the skin around her nails while Adora paces back and forth and smooths down her dress again. A hand floats up to her hair and Adora starts to open her mouth, but this time, Catra cuts her off.

"Yes, Adora. You look fine. You look good, okay? Your hair is perfect and your dress is perfect and your makeup hasn't smudged. *Stop* asking."

Adora shoots her a sheepish grin and her pacing comes to a stop, but she still sways back and forth from her toes to her heels. Two of her fingers play with the fabric of her dress. "Sorry. I'm just nervous."

"I'm going to say it again."

“Don’t say it again.”

“They’re your parents, dude.”

“Ugh.”

Catra smirks and pushes off the wall. She grabs Adora’s hand, the one playing with her dress, and squeezes it. That gives Adora a moment of pause, thank god. Catra isn’t one for hand holding and soft words. But, the surprise only lasts a second before Adora powers on.

“It’s just, this is a big deal. I’ve never brought any significant other to one of their dinners, much less a woman. They know you’re coming, of course. They made a whole deal about how they had to add an extra seat to the table, and how we’re putting the waitstaff out, and all that, but they know.”

“You’re talking way too fast,” Catra comments, squeezing her hand again.

Adora deflates, her shoulders hunching forward. “What if they see right through us? What if they don’t believe we’re together and then think that I’m lying about being gay, too?”

“Fuck what they think.”

Adora frowns and Catra can see the argument coming, but she holds up a finger.

“You’re gay whether they believe you or not. It’s not their choice. And, I’m a damn good actor, I can make it convincing.”

By now, Catra’s well used to Adora’s anxiety and general scatter-brainedness, but even this seems ramped up. Adora’s hand shakes in her own, and her eyes dart between Catra's face and their shoes.

“What if I’m not believable?”

Catra chews on her lip. That is a reasonable fear, they all know Adora to be a pretty bad actor. “I guess we have to practice.”

“Practice what-”

Catra uses her free hand to pull Adora in by the collar of her dress.

It takes almost a full second for Adora to react to Catra’s kiss. In that second, Catra gets to wonder if she made a mistake, but then Adora is kissing her back and- and.

This was supposed to be a quick peck. To break the ice in case they need to do this later, with an audience. But Adora brings her hand to Catra’s jaw and angles her to the right and they’re *really* kissing. Catra’ is warm from head to toe and her only thought is Adora - Adora’s lips, her fingers on Catra’s cheek, her other hand in Catra’s. She could lose herself to this.

But - it’s Adora.

Catra breaks away quickly, and the shock in Adora’s eyes when they open is enough to jolt Catra back into her own body, to replace her surprise with the comedic charm she likes to carry herself with.

“See? Practice isn’t so bad,” Catra says airily, choosing to ignore her thundering heart and the lingering warmth on her lips.

A laugh wipes away the rest of Adora’s shock and she rolls her eyes. “Yeah, yeah. Whatever. Let’s go inside.”

Catra lets Adora lead them out of the dark corner they had chosen to stand in. She follows closely, her eyes trained on Adora’s back, and desperately tries to calm the racing heart in her chest.

Catra almost slams into Adora's back. Adora has frozen midstep, and her hand goes limp in Catra's grip.

"Adora, what-" Catra peeks around her shoulder and concrete fills her stomach.

Oh, fuck.

Adora's parents haven't noticed them yet. They're sampling wine provided by the waiter, who stands by with elegant posture. Then, the third guest at the table waves a hand, and the waiter fills his glass.

The third guest. A man, around their age, in a perfectly tailored suit and professionally slicked back hair. When he flashes a stiff smile at the waiter, his too-white teeth blaze in the dim restaurant lighting.

"What is this," Adora says, though she doesn't move.

Finally, Marlene looks up, and Catra doesn't miss the way her eyes cut to their joined hands before bothering to look at Adora's face. "You're late. We've already started on the wine."

"Mom, who is this?" The sharp edge of her voice is unfamiliar to Catra, and she feels a quick beat of pride for her friend.

The man stands from the table with a celebrity smile and holds his hand out. "Adora. So nice to finally meet you. I've heard all about

you from Marlene here."

Immediately, Adora drops Catra's hand to shake the man's, and Catra hopes her dissatisfaction doesn't show on her face.

"Robert," he introduces himself, when Adora doesn't speak. He moves back to pull her chair out for her. And Adora moves stiffly to accept the gesture.

Catra sticks her own hand out to Robert, chin high. "I'm Catra. Adora's girlfriend."

Everyone at the table seems to freeze. From the corner of her eye, Catra can see Randall's face immediately turn cherry red. She doesn't break eye contact with the man, and the confusion in his face almost makes this whole thing worth it.

"Right. Nice to meet you." He shakes her hand quickly and turns back to the table. "Marlene, what did you think of the wine sample?"

Catra takes her seat next to Adora and exchanges a quick glance with her. Her hand is fisted in her dress and all the angles of her face are tense. Still, she smiles at Catra.

For a moment, Catra is taken back to the dark corner outside the restaurant, her hand fisted in the collar of Adora's dress and the warmth of her body pressed against Catra's.

Catra blinks hard, and Adora is saying her thanks to the waiter as he pours wine into her glass. The waiter appears over Catra's shoulder and she flinches, brain working overtime to catch up.

"Ma'am?" The waiter says, and Catra realizes he's asked her a question.

"Oh. Yes, thank you." The waiter nods and fills her glass. She looks to Adora, who swirls her wine around her glass and takes a delicate sniff. Jesus, who is she? The girl Catra's spent the last several years getting to know has drank box wine out of coffee

mugs and taken shots of cheap, flavored Smirnoff at group movie nights. That girl doesn't match up to the one in front of her, sitting with perfect posture and a placid smile on her face.

Catra tries her best to contribute to the conversation. She doesn't quite follow the professional aspect, and Robert doesn't miss any opportunity to butt in with his own recent business ventures. Apparently, his father is grooming him to take over a yacht manufacturing company, and Catra has to stifle a laugh the first time he mentions it.

"It's a win-win situation," Robert says while leaning in close to Adora, and Catra gets the fleeting urge to splash her wine into his blinding smile. "Our engineers are taking it to the next level with these new designs, and even if they don't sell in our own company, these designs are so adaptable for the lower-hanging fruit in the business. The data never lies."

"Your engineers sound commendable," Adora says lightly, and Catra doesn't think she's ever heard Adora use that word in real life. She turns to Catra and laces their fingers together, laying their hands on the table so everyone can see. "Catra is an engineer!"

"Oh-" Robert starts, his discomfort immediate, but Catra smiles at him sharply.

"Mechanical." She takes a long sip of her wine before continuing, melting easily into the suave character she imagines Adora will actually end up with someday. She points up at the ceiling. "This kind of sprinkler system is outdated in the fire protection world. My company is working on an early suppression sprinkler system that can contain a fire at its source."

Catra smiles at Robert. "What kind of system are you using on these new yachts? I hope it's something like ESFR."

It's fun, Catra discovers, to watch a man flounder. Robert opens and closes his mouth.

“Robert,” Marlene breaks in. “Tell Adora about the yacht you designed, the one that won the yacht races in the Great Lakes.”

The look she gives Catra is not quite a glare. No, she’s probably far too composed for that sort of outright emotion during a business meeting. That’s what this is, really. A deal to barter off her daughter onto some rich guy, just like Adora said.

Robert jumps on the topic, ready to ramble on about his own successes again, but his momentary stumble seems to have given Adora confidence.

“That’s a good point, what kind of fire system do yachts even use? Can you imagine a boat that size going up in flames in the middle of a race?” Adora chuckles.

“Personally, I’d find out what type of prevention I would use before designing something like that.” Catra responds.

Marlene clears her throat, but Adora’s eyes don’t leave Catra’s.

“You know, I think *our* apartment is supposed to be bringing us a new extinguisher soon. Ours is almost expired.”

“I thought I had already talked to maintenance about that. Sorry, babe, I’ll call them again in the morning.”

Robert finally finds the audacity to cut in. “How long have you two been friends?”

Friends. Catra lets herself laugh at that. Seriously? Their hands are literally clasped together on the table in front of him. “Friends? Several years. But our one year anniversary is coming up next month.”

“I’ve been planning for a month,” Adora grants Robert a short glance before turning her attention back to Catra, ever the adoring girlfriend.

“I hate surprises,” Catra laments with a dramatic frown at her girlfriend.

“You’ll like this one. I promise.” And Adora leans forward for a kiss. It’s quick this time, just a peck, and Adora pulls away before Catra can even process the sudden flood of warmth in her chest.

It doesn’t make sense. She’s kissed girls before. Hell, she kissed Adora once, years ago, on a drunken dare. It didn’t feel like this. It didn’t-

“Marlene,” Robert says sharply, standing. “I’m afraid I must excuse myself. I’ve…” For the second time tonight, Robert seems to fumble for words. “Important business call that I’ve forgotten about.”

Randall stands as well, a placating hand out over the table. “Robert, please. We haven’t even gotten our food-”

“I appreciate the invitation. We’ll talk soon.” Robert stalks away, his pretense of composure dissipating with every step.

Adora’s grip on Catra’s hand is almost painful. Silence descends on the table, and Randall watches Robert leave with an angry spark in his eyes. Slowly, he sits, and his raging gaze lands on Adora.

“What do you think you’re doing?” He asks, voice low, dangerous.

Again, pride blooms in Catra’s chest when Adora laughs, sharp and bitter. “Really, dad? What are *you* doing? Inviting me and my girlfriend out to set me up with some guy?” Before Randall can speak, Adora shoves her chair out from under her and stands. “I’ll see you at home. Catra?”

Catra doesn’t have to be told twice. She stands, a sickly sweet smile on her face as she thanks Adora’s parents for the wine.

Outside the restaurant, Adora marches back to the same dark corner they stood in before, and her bravado finally collapses. She swings around to face Catra, eyes wide, panic setting in.

“Holy shit,” Catra says quickly, before Adora can freak. “That was… you are… *dude.”*

“I can’t believe I did that.”

“I can’t believe you did that!” Catra laughs and jumps forward, wrapping her arms around Adora’s shoulders. In all their years of friendship, the amount of hugs between the two friends can be counted on one hand. But, Adora doesn’t miss a beat, hugging her tightly. “That was awesome. I’m impressed.”

Adora’s voice comes out weak and shaky. “Am I a cool girlfriend yet?”

“The coolest.”

It’s probably the longest hug Catra’s had in her life, but she waits until Adora lets go first. Waits until the shaking in the hands gripping the back of Catra’s shirt fades.

“You ready?” Catra says into her shoulder. She can feel the deep, grounding breath Adora takes, and somehow she’s not ready when Adora finally steps away.

“Are you? There will be screaming.”

“I can fight,” Catra shrugs.

“Please don’t punch my dad.”

“Fiiiiiine.”

It’s worse than either of them prepared for.

Marlene and Randall get back later, having actually stayed for dinner at the restaurant, and it’s chaos as soon as they open the door. Catra stands by Adora’s side for all of it, but she holds her own, shooting back defenses at her parents.

“Do you understand how you’ve embarrassed us?” Randall shouts, pacing back and forth, face red.

“Embarrassed *you?* What about me? Inviting my *girlfriend* on a blind date with another guy. This is ridiculous!” Adora’s eyes are sharp, lips in a tight scowl that Catra’s never seen before. Her hands are fisted at her sides.

“You shouldn’t have brought your fling with you on an actual, decent endeavor like this.”

“Fling!” Adora finally raises her voice.

Marlene scoffs. “When will you grow up, Adora? You’re twenty-five now. You need to find someone of similar status and settle down before it’s too late.”

“I *am* settling down. With Catra.”

Catra rests her hand on Adora’s shoulder and rubs comforting circles into her skin. It’s a gesture she’s never done before. She’s felt it before, years ago, broken down on Adora’s couch. She remembers crying until she couldn’t anymore and Adora sitting with her through all of it. Letting her fall apart, rubbing circles into

her skin. From the way Adora leans into her touch, she thinks it might be helping.

"You know what I mean." Marlene rolls her eyes, the first crack in her cool exterior.

Adora's spine steel under Catra's palm. "No, mom. I don't. Please tell me."

"Don't act like this is a permanent thing." Marlene's voice is stone. "You two are messing around. And you-" she glares at Catra. "-Are messing with Adora's future."

Throughout this conversation, Catra has let Adora take the lead. Let her decide how she wants to deal with this insanity. But now, she lets her hand drop from Adora's shoulder to her hand and raises her chin to stare Marlene in her eyes. "I *am* her future."

Marlene's jaw tenses, and Adora squeezes Catra's hand in gratitude. She holds up a hand, shutting her mother down.

"You should leave."

Both Marlene and Randall freeze at that. Randall finally stops pacing to stare incredulously at his daughter. "Adora, it's almost ten PM-"

"There are a few motels nearby. I'll order you an Uber."

Marlene steps back as if Adora hit her. "A motel-"

"You should listen to your daughter," Catra says, voice low, chin high.

It seems that Randall and Marlene have finally run out of words. They stare, eyes darting between Adora and Catra. Again, Marlene's glare drops down to their hands.

In the silence, Adora pulls her phone out. "Your Uber is on the way. Turn the lights off when you leave, I'm going to bed." She

squeezes Catra's hand before she drops it and walks away without a look back at her parents. Catra waits until she hears the door close, then turns emotionless eyes at Marlene.

"I can't imagine what it would be like," she says softly. "To have parents like you."

They don't respond as she follows Adora to her room.

Adora sits on her bed in the dark, having not bothered turning the lights on. She looked so tall and confident out there, and here, she's tiny. She curls into herself when Catra walks in.

Catra takes in her form from the doorway. Double checks that the bedroom door is locked behind her. Debates giving her space. But Adora hasn't ever asked for space when she's upset, so Catra pushes herself forward. She doesn't speak - what is there to say right now? - but she listens to Adora's stuttered breath, listens to the commotion outside the door as her parents pack. Catra's knee presses into Adora's, and neither moves away.

Eventually, after what feels like too long, the light bleeding through the cracks of the bedroom door shuts off, and Catra hears the front door shut. Beside her, Adora's breath catches, and Catra twitches in response. What if she starts crying? Catra isn't very good with that. What would Bow do? Make brownies or something, probably. Catra can't bake.

"Come on," Catra gets to her feet and offers her hand. Adora takes it, but hesitates before she follows Catra off the bed.

Catra leads her to the living room and turns one of the lamps back on - barely enough to illuminate the space, but the low lighting makes the room cozier. She sets Adora down on the couch and ignores her questioning look. She bustles around, finding Adora's favorite blanket in her bedroom, putting Adora's cute floral kettle on the stove, rifling through her cabinets. She only pauses to turn the TV on and flip through Netflix before she finds what she's looking for.

“Mamma Mia?” Adora asks, her voice rough.

Catra shrugs and heads back to the kitchen. Mamma Mia has been Adora’s comfort movie since before they met. A few times in college, when they shared an apartment, Catra had come home to Adora curled up in front of the TV watching Meryl Streep dance on screen. Whenever that happened, Catra had always beelined for the freezer and joined her on the couch with ice cream.

The kettle screams at Catra while she rifles through the bowl of tea bags, looking for the lemon ginseng that she knows helps Adora sleep better at night. Finally, she joins Adora on the couch with two pale yellow cups of tea.

They sit in silence, and every time Catra glances over, Adora’s eyes are unfocused in the light of the TV. She drains her cup, even though Catra knows she didn’t steep it long enough. Adora makes the best tea, and Catra tries…

Around midnight, Donna helps Sophie get ready for her wedding, and Catra hears a sniffle by her side. Fear twists her stomach as a tear slides down Adora’s face. Fuck, she’s *really* not good at this. But, something is better than nothing, right? She bumps Adora’s knee with her own, and Adora swipes at her face.

“They probably won’t come to my wedding.”

“Adora-”

“I’ll always be a disappointment, won’t I?” Tears brim in Adora’s eyes, and something in Catra’s heart clenches. Catra takes a deep breath, then sits up on her knees and leans into Adora’s space.

“This is bullshit. Your parents are being fucking *stupid,* Adora.” Catra keeps her voice level, but her anger toward Adora’s parents burns her throat. “Don’t make the decision of whether you’re worthy of people on their behalf, cause that’s not your decision to make. All you have to do-” Catra pokes her collarbone, and Adora gives her a small, watery smile. “-is accept the love other people choose to throw your way. It’s *my* choice to be your friend, and

Bow and Glimmer's choice, and we choose to because *we* love you. You don't have to change anything about yourself to be loved."

Her face crumples and Catra panics. Oh, fuck, she fucked up, she made Adora cry-

Adora doesn't have to lean forward far for her head to hit Catra's shoulder, and somehow, Catra's arms instinctively slide around her shoulders as if they've done this a million times before. Somewhere, in the back of Catra's mind, she adds another tally to the count of hugs she's exchanged with Adora in her lifetime.

They stay like that for a while. With Catra running her fingers up and down Adora's back, half in her lap at her awkward angle. Adora's sniffles peter off, but she doesn't move. Eventually, Catra gives herself the task of undoing Adora's hair, still up in a fancy braided bun. Her fingers move deftly through Adora's hair and she doesn't budge from Catra's shoulder. Maybe she's fallen asleep?

Adora's hair falls loose down her back in a smooth sheet, wavy from the braids, and Catra brushes her fingers through it. It's not necessary, her hair isn't tangled, but the action soothes Catra. Hopefully it helps Adora, too.

It takes until the movie ends and the TV goes dim from inactivity for Adora to rouse. Slowly, she peels herself away from Catra and looks up. Her eyes are piercing blue in the low light, accentuated by the red puffiness in her skin. Catra sits back, her legs having gone numb ages ago, and watches Adora carefully for more tears. Adora's lips break into a small smile, and then she laughs. Quiet, a little hoarse.

"You look scared."

"You were crying!" Catra defends immediately, frowning. "That's scary."

Adora's smile grows and she stands. "Come on. Let's go to bed."

No one mentions that her parents aren't in the guest bedroom anymore. There's no reason for them to share. Adora exchanges her now wrinkled dress for an oversized shirt and crawls under the covers. Holds the other side open for Catra. She crawls into the bed next to Adora and pats the pillows around, getting comfortable.

Adora waits until she settles down to slide closer. She presses her back against Catra's chest and curls into a crescent moon

"This okay?" Adora whispers, then yawns, and who is Catra to say no to her?

In response, Catra gingerly lets her arm rest across Adora's waist, lets her nose dip toward her hair.

"Okay," Adora says, half a sigh, and the stiffness leaves her shoulders.

This is selfish, Catra thinks. It's been years since she's held anyone like this - and never Adora. It's selfish, the way her heartbeat picks up its pace, the way Catra's mind blinks back to the dark corner outside the restaurant. Selfish, because this is Adora, her best friend, who is in shambles in her arms, and Catra can only think about the warmth of her skin beside her.

Catra hopes Adora doesn't feel the erratic beat of her heart. Hope she doesn't ask, because Catra doesn't have an answer. But, in just minutes, Adora's breath deepens, and Catra knows she's fallen asleep.

Catra is left to fend off her confusion alone and warm in Adora's bed.

Chapter End Notes

aaaaaaaaaaand that's all the hurt/comfort you guys get, we're all gay panic and fluff for the rest of this thank you very much

also i finally made a tumblr @ kadeswrongs

i have nothing on there yet but like it's around

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's being weird.

She's in the kitchen, actually cooking with Bow. No one knew how to respond when she asked in the group chat if she could cook with Bow at this week's Friday Night Dinner. Now, she's in there, listening attentively, and she hasn't even gotten irritated with Bow's instruction yet.

To top it off, when Adora walked in tonight, Catra barely looked at her. She had gotten the typical "Hey, Adora. Wine?" And a freshly poured glass before Catra had disappeared into the kitchen without a second glance.

Adora's eyes bore into the wall by the kitchen. She's at the perfect spot on the couch that she can't actually see over the counter into the kitchen, but she's buzzing with curiosity of what's going on in there. No, she's not a control freak, she's just interested, okay? Either way, Bow kicked her out after her second question and she's been stuck on the couch ever since. She just wants to know what's happening - in the kitchen, in their quiet conversation, with Catra's general oddity tonight-

"Why are you being so weird?"

Glimmer's face appears in front of Adora and she yelps, spilling wine onto her hand. Unimpressed, Glimmer hands her a napkin and raises an eyebrow. "Well?"

"What makes you say I'm being weird? I'm not being weird. I'm being Adora."

Glimmer still doesn't look impressed. She just sits back on the couch, stares at Adora, and sips her wine.

"What do you want from me?"

Finally, Glimmer lets out an exasperated sigh and rolls her eyes. "You didn't show up to coffee the other day when we all went out. And, all night long, you've just been staring at the wall, or standing up to look at Catra and going all red. Is this because she's cooking instead of you? It's literally not that big of a deal."

"I'm not jealous that Catra's cooking." Really, she's kind of proud of Catra. She doesn't do this often. Usually, she just mooches off of Bow and Adora's free cooking.

Glimmer gasps and sits forward. "Did you guys get in a fight?"

"No!" Adora sets her wine down and crosses her arms stiffly. "That's ridiculous."

"It's not ridiculous. You haven't talked about how it went with your parents at all, and Bow and I are *dying* to know. Spill."

Adora inspects the thrift store paintings on Bow's wall. "It was fine."

"Adora," Glimmer groans and lets her head fall back onto the couch. "Spill."

From the kitchen, something thumps loudly, and Catra laughs loudly. Okay, this time, Adora can feel the warmth in her cheeks. Maybe, maybe, she's still thinking about it. Thinking about Catra's

hands unbraiding her hair. Thinking about how Catra let her curl into her body in the bed, how well they fit together.

Glimmer snaps her fingers in front of Adora's eyes, making her flinch. "Snap out of it, dude!"

In one motion, Adora grabs Glimmer's wrist and stands. She ignores Glimmer's surprised curse as she drags them out the balcony door and slams it shut behind them.

"Adora, what-"

"We kissed."

Glimmer stares at Adora, hair ruffled and face indifferent. "...Right."

With a groan, Adora props her elbows on the railing of the balcony and drops her head onto her forearms.

"Sorry, just… wasn't that the plan?" Glimmer joins her on the railing, and Adora feels Glimmer's eyes on her, but she doesn't look up.

"Well, yeah! But then, it was, like, I don't know-"

"Good lord," Glimmer mutters.

"It just, like, and Catra, and then-"

Glimmer huffs, tired of Adora's incomprehension of the English language. "You guys kissed for show but it was kind of nice, huh?"

"It was really nice," Adora mutters into her clasped hands.

"And you want to do it again."

"And I want to do it again."

Glimmer turns her back to the railing and leans against it, propping a foot up. "Thank god."

“What?” That makes Adora finally look up.

“I’ve been waiting for you guys to hook up for, like, four years now.”

“I- no- it’s not like-” Adora sputters, and Glimmer frowns at her.

“Will I at least be invited to the wedding?”

“Glimmer!” Adora snaps, finally regaining hold on her basic speaking skills. “Stop. It’s not like I want to *date* her. I think it was just nice to kiss someone.” As if she’s convincing herself, she nods quickly. “Right. It was just nice. Maybe it’s time for me to get back into the dating scene.”

“You’re so dumb-”

The glass door slides open and Bow, with some sort of fresh stain on his shirt and a carrot peel stuck to his pants, smiles brightly at them. “Dinner’s ready!”

“Bow,” Glimmer chides. “We were having a heart-to-heart.”

“A heart to heart?” Bow clasps his hands together. “That’s my favorite! Can I join? What’s going on? Is it about Cat-”

Adora huffs and pushes past both intrusive friends.

Even after an hour of checking, the phone stays quiet.

Adora pretends she isn't looking every few minutes, pretends she isn't keeping one eye on the black phone screen. Usually, the monotone of her analytics professor is broken up by Catra's texts. Stupid memes shot back and forth, updates about what Catra's coworkers are doing, even the dual lamenting of how bored they both are. It all keeps Adora entertained enough to stop her from daydreaming in class.

Today, there's nothing. No infrequent messages, no pictures of Catra's lunch. In all honesty, Adora didn't realize until now how much those trivial texts keep her sane. It's almost been two weeks since dinner with her parents, and still, the text chain between Adora and Catra is empty.

Even the weekly calls from Adora's mom - Tuesday and Thursday, at eleven AM - didn't happen. The first week, Adora had sat by her phone in the regular study room she booked with her notebook and Excel sheet open. These calls were never about mother-daughter bonding. Strictly business, with updates about the company and adding onto Adora's own classwork. Eleven AM had come and gone without a call from her mother. Thursday, she prepared again, sitting in the study room, and nothing.

Full blown silence from her best friend *and* her own mother.

Her phone screen lights up and she almost smacks it straight off her desk in her hurry to grab it. Another weather channel update - there's a storm coming in tonight.

"Are you on crack?" A voice whispers from beside her.

Mermista spins her pen around her fingers, reclined back in her seat and not even pretending to listen to the professor. As always, she looks wholly disinterested. Her laptop has gone black from disuse.

"I've never done crack, and I never will, thank you." Adora turns her phone off and puts it face down on the table. She looks at it for a second, then flips it over, just in case the screen lights up again.

"What's Catra up to?"

Adora frowns and copies the words from the projector down into her notebook. "Dunno."

"Aren't you guys literally joined at the hip? What, have a fight or something?"

"Why does everyone think - *ugh."*

"My bad." Mermista doesn't seem remorseful in the slightest.

Adora tries her best. She focuses on the professor's slow, flat lecture. She writes down the notes that appear on the board and adds footnotes in her favorite pink pen of things she thinks she needs to review later. For all of three minutes, she tries.

She doesn't even notice she's zoned out until Mermista sneezes next to her and Adora snaps back to attention. Her pen is pressed into the paper, bleeding out its precious pink ink, and she caps it quickly.

"What's up with you?" Mermista asks with a distinct lack of interest.

"What's up with *you?* " Adora shoots back with a vague gesture at Mermista's laptop screen. Several different pictures of flower arrangements take up her screen, from roses to baby's breath.

Mermista sighs heavily and scrolls down the page of arrangements. “Our anniversary is coming up and I have no idea what to get Seahawk.”

The soft part of Adora melts and she grins, leaning over the desk to get a better look. “Look at these daisies! That’s so sweet. He’s gonna cry.”

“He always cries.” Mermista pushes her laptop at Adora. “Help.”

They spend the rest of class adamantly ignoring the professor. Mermista’s insistence on the most meaningful bouquet, and her fierce blush as she denies it, fills Adora with glee from head to toe. She can only imagine loving, and being loved, like this, but she thrives watching her friends do this anyway.

In the end, Mermista settles on a broad bouquet of blue delphinium, sweet pea, and thistle, and Adora fawns over the raging red on her face while she checks out. The distraction is good enough that she temporarily forgets her friendship woes. That is, until her phone finally lights up. This time, she avoids almost throwing her phone off the table, but it’s not Catra texting her.

Glimmer: any word from your parents?

Adora: Still nothing

Glimmer: any word from Catra?

Adora: No…

Glimmer: UUUUUUUUUUGH I CANT DO ANOTHER AWKWARD FRIDAY NIGHT DINNER

Adora: It literally wasn’t that bad

Glimmer: UUUUUUUUUGGGGGGGGGGGGGGHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH ok im taking manners into my own hands

Adora: ????????

The professor shuts the projector off and there's a bustle of activity as everyone collects their belongings. Adora takes her time, placing her pens back into their designated pockets in her bag and folding up her notebook. Beside her, Mermista unceremoniously dumps her laptop and book into her bag and leaves with a short wave. Finally, Adora's phone lights up again with a message in the group chat.

Glimmer: movie night at my place at 7 if anyones late you have to take an extra shot

Bow: MOVIE NIIIIIIIIIIGHT

Catra: I have work tomorrow, I can't

Adora frowns at that. It's rare that Catra turns down any invitation in the group, regardless of her schedule. They've had nights where they've stayed up until two AM playing games with the group, or just the two of them drinking wine, and Catra still went to work at eight the next morning.

Glimmer: ok and? Be there at 7

Catra: Fine but I'm not drinking

Glimmer: lame

Catra: Maybe one drink, but no shots

A classmate passing by shoots Adora an odd look as she laughs to herself, but she doesn't mind. Oh, Catra. Always the one to accept Glimmer's plots, never the one to admit it.

Glimmer: unless you're late

Catra: I won't be late

Bow: MOVIE NIIIIIIIIIIGHT

Glimmer: Adora?

Bow: Adora?

Catra: Adora?

It’s the most attention Catra’s shown her in days, and Adora can’t decide if she’s happy about it. Okay, yeah, phones go both ways, and Adora hasn’t sent any texts in Catra’s direction either. Still, the radio silence feels muddy and unfamiliar.

Adora: I won’t be late

Adora runs.

Feet pounding pavement. Breath coming in sharp gasps. She’s done this before, and she’ll do this again, but by god, she did *not* want to do it tonight.

She bursts through Bow’s door with her usual lack of grace and a shot glass appears in her hands before she even fully stops.

“We had it ready for you,” Glimmer says sweetly, a wicked glint in her eyes.

“I haven’t even had dinner-”

“Shots! Shots! Shots!” Glimmer demands, and Bow joins in from the couch without hesitation. “Shots! Shots! Shots! Shots!”

“Fine!” Adora throws back the shot and immediately cringes at the sharp burn. “I wasn’t even that late,” she coughs out.

“Late is late,” Catra says, kicked back on the couch next to Bow and watching the whole scene with muted amusement.

Fuck, Adora can’t help it. Her body tenses up again just from the sound of Catra’s voice. A moment of silence passes in which Adora is obviously supposed to respond, and Glimmer cuts her a look dripping with exasperation before saving her.

“It’s 7:06. That’s late. Come on, we’re watching Twilight and drinking every time we cringe.” Glimmer saunters over to the couch and drops down next to Bow, leaving the only open spot next to Catra.

It’s not weird. This is how they always sit, crammed onto Bow’s couch that’s just big enough for the four of them to squeeze onto comfortably. But Adora still hesitates. She tries to ignore Glimmer’s pointed stare at her. Catra doesn’t look up, focused on something on her phone. The lights are low in preparation for the movie, and the light from Catra’s phone sends blue highlights over her jaw and cheekbone, and Adora stares.

Only when Catra finally glances up does Adora unfreeze. She kicks off her shoes and hurries to the couch in a rush that she knows isn’t casual enough. She doesn’t have to look at Glimmer to check. “Twilight? Didn’t we do that last year?”

“Exactly,” Bow says resolutely. *“Last* year. It’s been way too long! This one’s yours.” He holds out a light pink drink. “Tell me what you think.”

Outside of their Friday Night Dinners, Bow’s been experimenting with cocktails. Some are good, some are… alcohol. Gingerly, Adora takes a sip, and immediately brightens. “Ooh! I like this,

You nailed the simple syrup to gin ratio this time. Is that grapefruit?”

While Bow thoroughly explains the process of making the cocktails, Adora tries her best to listen and relax into the couch cushions. But, Catra is right next to her, so close that their arms touch if Adora breathes too deeply. It’s how it always is. So why can’t she just relax?

“Okay, let’s all agree the cocktails are great. Can I play the movie now?” Glimmer finally cuts Bow off, sometime into his rant about the process of making whiskey. “A drink to start off!”

They all clink their glasses, and Adora’s knee touches Catra’s as she does. Did she imagine her flinch? It’s probably just Adora’s own body, right?

It takes two minutes into the movie before Bow says “yikes” at the screen and they all take another sip of their drink. As the movie plays, Adora slowly, *painfully* slowly, starts to relax into the couch. As much as she loves to deny it, she’s a bit of a lightweight, and the shot combined with her cocktail definitely helps keep the tension out of her shoulders. Halfway through her drink, the pizza finally arrives, and they break to eat.

Adora plans to give the others a minute to get their pizza, mostly because she’s comfortable and her spot is warm and she’s not quite ready to move, but a plate appears on her lap.

“One pepperoni and one of Bow’s abominations, right?” Catra asks, and there’s a weird look on her face that Adora can’t quite name. She’s looking right at Adora, but it feels like she’s forcing it. Like it’s a deliberate action.

“It’s not an abomination.” Even through her confusion and her general nerves from the way Catra’s looking for it, she can still defend her pizza. “Banana peppers and olives are good, you just have to try them.”

Something relaxes in Catra's face. She looks softer now, less like she's making herself meet Adora's eyes. The thought tightens something in Adora's chest. Is she mad at Adora? Is she upset that Adora tried to cuddle with her in bed?

Oh, god, wait.

All of this, the radio silence, the tension when they're in a room together. It's because Catra didn't want that, isn't it? Catra is a good friend. She wouldn't say no if Adora needed emotional support. And Catra has never ever extended any sort of physical affection to anyone in their group. Adora made her uncomfortable, didn't she?

Now, confusion shadows Catra's face, and she takes a step back. "Dude, are you o-"

"Shots!" Glimmer calls from the kitchen. "It's time!"

Catra doesn't look away. Her brows knit together and she opens her mouth to speak but Adora shoots up to her feet, barely saving the pizza. "Shots!" She calls back, and walks away as fast as her feet can carry her.

Adora pours herself a shot and throws it back before Catra and Bow even join them in the kitchen. She ignores Glimmer's odd look and mumbles something about the bathroom as she walks away. In the bathroom, quiet and alone, Adora stares at the wall. She's really fucked up, hasn't she? She made her best friend uncomfortable, and she still can't get over how she liked the feeling of Catra's arms around her. How she liked letting her head rest on her collarbone when they were on the couch.

Where does she go from here? How can she make it up to her friend? *Can* she make it up to her?

Adora closes her eyes and takes a deep, grounding breath. She knows now what went wrong, and she can fix it in the morning, without alcohol in her system. Her stomach growls and she opens her eyes. Right, pizza first, then Twilight, then sleep, *then* panic.

By the time she goes back to the living room, everyone is on the couch munching on pizza, and Bow's refilled all the drinks. Catra is staring at her, and Adora only glances at her briefly. Her guilt tries to bubble back up in her stomach, but she presses forward and takes her seat on the couch.

"Finally," Glimmer says through a mouth of pizza. She presses play, and she almost immediately groans at Bella's overzealous lip bite. "Drink!"

Adora is three cocktails, two shots, and at least half a pizza in when Glimmer puts on the second Twilight. No one complains, though the movie's somehow become a lot funnier. Definitely not to be owed to the alcohol. Glimmer and Bow take turns narrating the movie like a bad, tipsy audiobook. Bow waves his hands in the air as he narrates, and Catra leans away to give him space, right into Adora.

At first, Adora stiffens, unsure what to do with her body. But, Catra readjusts, and her shoulder rests against Adora's. Their knees press together, and Catra gives her a small, secret smile that has Adora reeling in confusion that Catra doesn't see, already turned back to the movie.

"Hear me out," Bow says, voice a little slurred. Adora might be a lightweight, but Bow can't handle his alcohol to save his life. "Bella literally only laughs when she's with Jacob."

"Do not-" Glimmer immediately starts.

“I said hear me out!” Bow pushes at Glimmer’s knee, and he leaves his hand resting there as he speaks. Catra exchanges a wide-eyed look with Adora, and they both have to stifle their laugh. At least that feels normal, teasing their friends for their inability to notice their raging crushes on each other. “I know he’s a total dick later, but he’d be way more comfortable to sleep with.”

Catra’s nose wrinkles. “Ew. I don’t want to think about sex with Jacob.”

“Literal sleep!” Bow defends again. “Edward’s all hard and cold, at least Jacob feels like a human. Can you imagine trying to hold hands with a statue?”

“Some people have cold hands, Bow.” Catra snorts. Out of all of them, Catra holds her alcohol the best, but she does get giggly. Adora loves to see it. “Adora *always* has cold hands.”

Adora gasps, offended. “Don’t bring me into this! My hands are perfectly un-vampire-y.”

Catra scrutinizes Adora for a brief second, then scoops up her hand and laces their fingers together. Just like they did in front of Adora’s parents. And later on, when Adora was panicking. Like it was the easiest thing in the world. Like they’ve done it a million times. Catra watches her face, eyes flicking back and forth between Adora’s. Then, she nods sharply. “Cold.”

“Hey!” Adora’s indignation almost overshadows the tingling in her hand where their skin meets. Almost. On the other side of the couch, Glimmer continues arguing with Bow, and Catra finally breaks eye contact to watch, but she leans further into Adora. She doesn’t let go of Adora’s hand.

Chapter End Notes

next chapter on friday 4/18!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She's about to go crazy. It's been almost two weeks, and Adora still hasn't texted her. Catra tried. Sort of. Melog had fallen asleep upside down on the counter, and she'd snapped a picture. Adora responded with heart emojis and left it at that.

Last night, she guesses she had a brief moment of insanity when she grabbed Adora's hand. But, Adora responded immediately by intertwining their fingers and giving her hand a squeeze, so Catra didn't let go. Even as they laughed at the movie, even as Glimmer and Bow argued about Edward and Jacob, Adora didn't drop her hand. Sometime toward the end of the movie, she let her free hand skim over Catra's knuckles. Catra had frozen, as if moving would break the spell, but Adora was focused on the movie. Catra doubted she even knew she was doing it.

On top of all of this, Adora hasn't talked about her family at all. The switch-up from crying into Catra's shoulder to silence about the whole thing is too jarring for Catra. Usually, Adora spills anything and everything that's going on in her life.

Melog climbs straight onto Catra's chest and promptly curls up. She's reclined back on her couch with the lights off. The sun tries to push past her blackout curtains, but she prefers to mope in the dark. Still, she holds her phone up above the burdensome cat who never seems to care about anyone else's comfort and stares at the screen.

The text thread is still empty. It's just the picture of Melog, his teeth sticking out from his lips as he sleeps, and the heart emoji response.

This is so stupid. They've been friends for so many years. They've even had fights before where they didn't talk for a few days. Sure, Adora hasn't sent any messages, but Catra hasn't really mustered the courage to text her, either. She knows it's because Adora's caught up. She has to be dealing with a lot, with her parents, with her Master's classes, with figuring out what to do with the company. Catra knows she's on the backburner, and she doesn't mind - Adora needs time to figure her own shit out. Whatever confusing feelings Catra is having are to be dealt with quietly.

It doesn't stop Catra from missing her. It's stupid, it's not like she's gone. They just haven't talked. She can be patient, she can give Adora her space-

Catra is typing before she's even fully formed her thought.

Catra: So? When can I cash in my free dinner?

Immediately, she stands, knocking Melog onto the couch as she does. He meows angrily, but turns over and goes right back to sleep anyway. Oh well, Catra has bigger problems. She marches to the kitchen and starts on the dishes right away. Two whole plates get washed before Catra checks her phone. The text comes in as she's holding her phone, and Catra stops breathing for a second, until she actually reads it.

Adora: this is glimmer, she's out with the dogs

Disappointment fills Catra before she can stop it. Her first text from Adora's phone isn't actually from Adora. She frowns at the phone, then sets it down on the counter to pout about it, but another text comes in.

Adora: you should come by

Catra pretends to consider it. She refuses to acknowledge, even to herself, that she's already made the decision. Washing another plate, eyes on the phone, Catra pretends. And then suddenly she's at the door, motorcycle helmet in hand and a leather jacket slung over her shoulder. She's not very good at pretending.

The sun beats down on Catra's shoulder as she rides to Bright Moon Dog Daycare. She relishes the warmth in her shoulders, the wind on her neck, the motorcycle underneath her. The comfort is short lived, although she takes the long way. Soon enough, she's parked in front of Bright Moon.

Briefly, Catra imagines turning the bike back on and going home. Melog would be happy to see her, and she knows the sun is in the right spot in the sky that she could open a window and curl up on the couch to nap in the sunbeams. That sounds a lot easier than this.

The front door opens, and Glimmer pokes her head out. "Are you planning on coming inside, or are you gonna sit there forever?"

Catra scowls, more upset by the act of being caught than Glimmer's actual teasing. Still, she takes her helmet off and stands. Glimmer holds the door open for her, already ranting about some new dog that's showed up, but Catra barely hears her. Walking slowly, as if she can prolong this moment, Catra clutches at her helmet and steps inside.

Silence finally meets Catra's ears and she glances over at Glimmer, who has her arms crossed. "You didn't hear a word I said."

"I was listening. There's a… new dog… and…"

Glimmer pinches the bridge of her nose with two fingers. “She’s in the big dog pen.” With that, she walks behind the counter and goes back to typing something into the system.

Catra could have guessed that by herself. Despite her own lack of interest in the species, she’s been privy to far too many of Adora’s dog rants. She’s even been here once or twice, on Adora’s insistence, to meet some of her favorite daycare regulars.

Catra sets her helmet down on the counter and rolls her shoulders, eyes locked on the door to the outside pens.

“It’s not a bad thing to like your friends,” Glimmer says offhandedly. Catra wheels around to stare at her, but Glimmer doesn’t look up from the computer.

Catra waits for any sort of follow-up, but Glimmer doesn’t seem inclined to give any. After far too much silence for Catra’s liking, she stalks to the door and shoves it open.

The noise of the dogs makes Catra want to turn on her heel, but there she is. Adora is laying on her back, one arm crossed behind her head, the other entangled in the fur of a husky curled against her side. There’s a german shepherd laying directly on top of Adora’s stomach, and Catra briefly wonders if she can breathe okay. One of Adora’s feet is propped up on another dog, and Catra takes a second to try to place the breed as she walks up to the fence. But, apparently she hasn’t listened to Adora’s rants closely enough. Looks like a dog, to Catra.

“Sleeping on the job is unprofessional.” Catra leans on the fence. She sees the second Adora registers her voice in the twitch of her fingers, but Adora takes her time before she opens one eye to look at her.

“They don’t even pay me,” she argues. The shepherd on her stomach shifts and she winces, but doesn’t try to move him.

“They shouldn’t pay negligent employees.”

“Maybe I’m negligent because I’m unpaid.”

Catra rolls her eyes, but a smile tugs at her lips anyway. The moment she hops the fence, several dogs swarm to her. She wrinkles her nose and tries to offer a pat to one of them. It doesn’t take long for the dogs to figure out she’s not going to give them much attention, and they filter off as she makes her way to Adora’s side.

“What’s this?” Catra points at the dog by Adora’s feet.

Adora follows her finger, looking down at the dog. Her eyes squint in the offensive sun, and Catra takes a second to watch. Has she ever noticed how blue Adora’s eyes are?

“He’s a purebred Rhodesian Ridgeback. This is Marco.” Adora tries her best to reach the dog, but the shepherd on her stomach doesn’t seem ready to move. Instead, Adora waves her hand uselessly in the air. “Ugh. Pet him?”

If anyone else asked, Catra would ignore them. But, this is Adora, and Catra’s already leaning down to scratch behind Marco’s ears. He opens his eyes and wags his tail a few times, then seems to go back to sleep. Catra retracts her hand as soon as she deems proper, and when she looks up, Adora has this weird, small smile on her face. It disappears the second Catra notices.

Adora clears her throat and pushes up to her elbows, finally disturbing the shepherd on her stomach enough that he slides pathetically to the grass. “So, you came to see the dogs? On purpose?”

“Do you really believe that?” Catra scoffs. “I’m here for you.”

Red blooms over Adora’s cheeks and Catra rushes to come up with an explanation.

“I haven’t gotten a single one of your dinners yet.” Catra sits on the ground and gingerly offers her hand to the husky to sniff.

Adora laughs, and Catra feels the tension in her skin finally relent as Adora sits up. “How about a lunch? Are you free now?”

“I’m free,” Catra smiles back. The husky gives her fingers a lick and she flinches away so hard she cracks an elbow. Immediately, she feels her face warming, but Adora starts laughing so hard she doubles over, and Catra feels a little better.

Adora gives the husky a pat on the head, still laughing, and stands. Offering Catra a hand, she grins down with a suddenly blinding smile. “Lunch, then.”

“Wait,” Catra says, even as she accepts Adora’s hand and lets herself get lugged to her feet by Adora’s consistently surprising strength. Seriously, everyone knows Adora’s a total gym rat, but anytime she shows it, they’re all taken off guard. “I have nothing in my pantry. And my place is a mess. And Melog will be annoying-”

“I love Melog!”

“I have no food!”

“We’ll stop at the store, then.”

While they walk out of the dog pen - slowly, Adora has to say goodbye to every dog - Adora is already rattling off recipes she might make. Catra offers opinions when she can, and Adora doesn’t seem surprised when she vehemently vetoes tomato soup. Ew.

Glimmer gives Catra a knowing look as they leave together, and Catra frowns in return. Glimmer doesn’t know. How could she? Catra doesn’t like to share her internal monologue. Let the others guess. Glimmer doesn’t know anything.

In the store, Adora runs through aisles like a madman, tossing all sorts of ingredients in Catra's cart. She teases Catra for her helmet hair, rambles about noodles, and disappears if Catra looks away for too long. While speedwalking through the store searching for Adora for the third time, Catra lets herself smile at the normalcy.

At Catra's apartment, she sits herself up on the counter to watch Adora work. She's always been good at making herself at home, and that doesn't end here. She rifles through Catra's cabinets with a purpose while the kettle starts to shriek on the stove. Through the whole process, she narrates what she's doing, why she wants their tea to steep exactly this long, why she's using this kind of sauce for the noodles, why she cooks the shrimp this long. Catra is content to sip her tea and observe.

"Stir real quick?" Adora says and promptly drops the sauce spoon. "Before it starts bubbling." She bustles away and Catra's eyes widen. She hastily slides off the counter and grabs the spoon, splashing some sauce up on the sides of the pan as she stirs.

"Spaz," Adora calls from the living room.

"You left me alone!" Catra defends, stirring quickly.

Adora reappears in the kitchen with Melog in her arms. "I had more important things to do." She sets the cat on a counter stool

and he curls up, watching the two girls with his startling blue eyes.

"This doesn't feel like free dinner."

"You're doing just fine." Adora walks over and reaches around Catra to turn the heat off. "Okay! Lunch is done."

Catra wants to argue more, but Adora's still too close, and she's focusing on staying in that air of normalcy they've finally built up today. She doesn't move, breathing deeply, and it doesn't help that Adora always smells like springtime.

That's it. There's only so much denying one can do before they can admit it. Catra has *feelings* for Adora. She's been waiting for this to go away. Waiting for the thought to stop wandering about in the back of her mind. Adora has too much going on with her career, with family, with school, to worry about Catra's momentary lapse in judgement.

"It's not going to bite you," Adora teases lightly, and Catra feels her curious look.

"You never know," Catra says, but her voice comes out strained.

Adora straightens and takes a step away. She clears her throat awkwardly. "Catra?"

"Adora?" Catra mocks, a bit weakly, and manages to look over. They're still too close. There's something in Adora's face that looks… unsure? Nervous? Adora chews on her lip before she takes a deep breath.

That's when Adora's phone rings.

She flinches away quickly and looks down at the phone on the counter. Then, she pales, like she's seen a ghost. "'"My mom," she says, almost whispering.

They both stare at the caller ID as if it's not real. Like they're waiting for it to go away. But, it doesn't change, and Adora looks at Catra with wide eyes.

"I need to answer it. Will you…" she trails off, but Catra nods resolutely. With a shaking hand, Adora accepts the call, and puts it on speaker. "Hello?"

Her voice is strong, betraying none of the shaking in Adora's body, and Catra gives her a smile that she hopes portrays her pride.

"Adora."

Whatever confidence Adora had seems to be crumbling. Without thinking, Catra reaches forward and takes her hand, giving it a squeeze. Adora squeezes back, and rolls her shoulders like she's preparing to go into the wrestling ring.

"I'm with Catra, is this important?"

"Hello, Catra. How are you?"

Catra flinches at the acknowledgement. Adora matches her shock, brows pulling together. "I'm great, thanks." She aims for a neutral tone.

"Good. Adora, there's a meeting with the head of Mystacor in Los Angeles next weekend. It aims to bring together the next generation of leadership and introduce them to the current social network."

"Okay…" Adora still looks at Catra, as if they're just speaking to each other. Catra shrugs, as confused as Adora, and takes a sip of her water.

There's a pause on the line, and Marlene clears her throat. "I will be going. And, the head of Mystacor, Castaspella, will be fronting the meeting. With her wife."

Catra chokes on her water and quickly turns, trying to cough silently.

"That's nice," Adora manages. Her grip on Catra's hand has turned to stone.

"I would like you to go." Another pause. "And you too, Catra. A lot of attendees are bringing their… partners."

A small smile creeps onto Adora's face. It's a tiny victory. Invisible in the grand scheme of things. But, not only did Marlene finally refer to Catra as her partner, but she wants their relationship to be public.

"I will buy your tickets," Marlene continues. "And I found a small beach house in Laguna Beach that will accommodate the both of you, and your friends, Gemma and Bryan."

"Glimmer and Bow," Adora corrects immediately. "Next weekend is a quick turnaround. I don't know if they can drop everything to go to California like that." Of course they will. Just two months ago, Glimmer missed a day of work to go to a new brunch spot four hours away because Adora had decided at three AM she wanted to go.

"I'll buy the tickets anyway, just in case."

"What's the catch?" Adora says, shoulders steeled, jaw set, even though her mother can't see her. Catra can't help the warmth in her chest. This Adora, her transformation from a nervous wreck to a warrior, is a sight not often seen. But when she comes out, she's impossible to ignore.

"I would like to have dinner with you."

"That's it?" The frown on Adora's face looks etched in her skin, and all Catra wants is to reach out and smooth it away. She shakes her head as if she can physically shake the thought from her head.

“There are some things I would like to discuss,” Marlene says, and only now does Catra realize she sounds tired.

Melog jumps onto the counter, and Adora scratches his chin as she thinks.

“I haven’t heard from dad.”

The silence from the phone feels like an icy breeze. Catra can almost feel Adora holding her breath.

“Give him time.”

Adora doesn’t respond to that. Her face storms over and she drops her eyes from Catra’s to the phone. Marlene sighs heavily.

“Well? Will you be there?”

“I’ll be there,” Adora confirms. “We’re having lunch, I have to go now.”

Catra’s almost forgotten about the sauce on the stove, probably cold by now. She opts to give Melog chin scratches while Adora and her mother say their goodbyes. Again, both are surprised when Marlene actually says goodbye to Catra, too.

When the call ends, Adora stares at the counter, collecting herself. She wordlessly joins Catra in petting Melog, and Catra watches her out of the corner of her eye.

“Are you sure you want to do this?” Catra finally breaks the silence.

Adora shrugs loosely. “It’s a great opportunity to make connections with the next gen. I’ve been corresponding - *shut up,”* she rolls her eyes at Catra’s scoff. *“Talking* with - better? - a lot of these people for a year, and meeting them in person is a big deal.”

“So I’ll be your girlfriend in front of all these important people?”

Adora’s eyes go comically wide and she sucks in a breath. “I didn’t even ask-”

“I’ll do it,” Catra cuts her off, a smirk on her face despite herself. “For three more free meals.”

Adora’s answering smile makes it all worth it, anyway.

Chapter End Notes

i straight up forgot today is friday soooooooorry for the late update

have some disaster catra, as a treat

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

> so, pretty much, life is hard and i don't have the time to finish this fic. i thought you guys should know the end anyway, and i'm so sorry to everyone who's been following this, because all i have is the bulleted outline and some super short scenes. i'll make sure to put that in the work summary as well. but thank you guys for following and enjoying this, and hopefully someday i can come back and finish this in a real way :)
>
> ****this bulleted outline is not edited whatsoever and has some of my personal notes in here, excuse any typos please and thank you :))

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

- Everyone runs through the airport trying not to miss their flight. Adora is laughing, Glimmer is trying to herd everyone around, Bow is just there for a good time, Catra is nonchalant as always but she laughs when Adora does
- Running through a crowd, Adora grabs Catra's hand, and their fingers thread together like second nature

Getting to the beach

- Collapsing through the front door, long ass day of flights, everyone's exhausted. The house is right on the beach - Adora is immediately excited, wants to run out to the water, Catra says they should change from airport clothes first and she turns to get ready. And then. *There are only two rooms.* (What's New Scooby Doo) No one misses the tension in the room and the incriminating non-look that Glimmer and Bow give each other.
- Adora and Catra share a look, they've been waiting for Glimmer and Bow to get together for a year.

- “I’m not sharing with Glimmer. She kicks.” Adora crosses her arms.
- “Catra-”
- “Fuck no, I happen to value my shins.”
- Adora links her arm with Catra’s and they stroll off to their room. They laugh and put all their bags on the bed - *the one bed* ;) - and Adora immediately disappears into the bathroom to change. “You better be ocean-ready by the time I’m out of here!”
- She takes her time braiding her hair just so (she remembers that Catra said she looked good in braids one time)
- She meets everyone on the back porch and doesn’t miss the way Catra’s eyes stick to her. Neither does Glimmer, apparently, and Glimmer waggles her eyebrows annoyingly, though she seems to be ignoring Bow persistent stare at the seagulls (AKA: anywhere but Glimmer)

Next night

- Adora goes out for dinner with her mother. Her mother cries and says that she always wanted the best for Adora, and she’s sorry that she didn’t deliver that to her. She said she was afraid of what it meant for Adora to be a lesbian in an industry like this, and how it would be more difficult for her. Adora says that it’s never difficult with Catra by her side. And that the person she loves doesn’t define her worth in the world. And she believes that people can change, and she hopes that her mother will accept her in the future. Adora’s mother cries more, and then says that she accepts her right now, and wants to prove it to her. She asks her to bring Catra to dinner at the end of their trip.

Next night

- Day full of adventures and touring the town. They go to a beach side aquarium and Glimmer sidles up to Adora, shocking her eyes away from Catra (she was staring at a tank full of fish and she looked mesmerized - maybe a little hungry. It was kind of adorable.)

- “You look a little thirsty, Adora”
- Catra hears. “Thirsty?” She looks innocent.
- For drinks! Yes, drinks, I saw a bar on the beach near the apartment. I’ve been thinking about it all day. I’m just. Thirsty. For drinks!
- (Nice save, Adora -Glimmer)
- (They teleport to the bar)
- They’re ordering rounds and Adora has been between dancing, making friends with the whole world, and collapsing at the table. She’s in a rush of ecstasy (and vodka) and her eyes keep getting stuck on the little shorts Catra is wearing. Her tattoos poke out beneath them and Adora wants to run her fingers over them. Kiss them. Taste her skin - woah. To distract herself, she flounces over to the bar and orders them more shots.
- “You look like you want to eat her” - Glimmer
- “God, I would,” Adora groans, upset at herself, and throws back a shot without waiting for the rest of the group.
- “What-” Glimmer starts, laughing, but Catra has appeared with a hand on Adora’s shoulder.
- “Taking shots without me? Asshole. Aren’t we supposed to be girlfriends, or something?” Catra is so much looser when she drinks vodka. She throws back a shot and Adora watches the bob of her throat as it goes down.
- “Wanna dance?” Adora manages. Catra laughs - so free.
- “I don’t dance.”
- “Do it for me?” Adora sounds so much more serious than she meant to.
- Catra sizes her up. “Yeah. Okay.” And then they’re on the floor.
- The beat is infectious. Catra looks a little unsure of herself at first, bobbing to the music.
- “Come on. You can do better than that.” Adora grabs her hands and brings them up into the air. They grin at each other, too close for subtlety. When she drops Catra’s hands, they end up on Adora’s shoulders. Adora doesn’t know how her hands got down there, but they’ve settled on Catra’s thighs, thumbs resting at the top of those little shorts.

They’re close enough that Adora can feel Catra’s breath catch when she presses one of her thumbs into her hip, and she’d do anything to feel it again. She pulls Catra closer and suddenly neither of them are laughing. Adora feels the beat but doesn’t hear it - doesn’t recognize the flashing lights in the club. The only color she cares about is that of Catra’s eyes. Catra’s hands slide down Adora’s back and pulls her closer. Adora’s hand is on her cheek, thumb grazing the edge of Catra’s lip, and she’s about to open her mouth and say something definitely dumb, until a body smacks into them and they’re both knocked off balance. Adora barely catches Catra’s waist, barely saves them both from falling to the beer stained floor.

- Bow throws out an apology over his shoulder, but he’s still whipping Glimmer around in circles around the dance floor. The other dancers have made space for them, but Adora and Catra totally missed the memo.
- Catra looks a little lost, looks around the area. Another couple raises their drinks to her and Adora. Adora watches as Catra goes literally bright red, mumbles something about the bathroom, and disappears
- Adora ends up back at their seat sipping on a new drink when Glimmer and Bow collapse next to her, laughing and gripping each other’s hands. They see the look on Adora’s face and ask what happened, and she shrugs it off. She says she’s headed back to the beach house and they’re disappointed, but tell her to go, they’ll stay. It’s a five minute walk anyway.

Later

- Adora is curled up on the porch with a hot chocolate and a blanket, listening to the waves. Footsteps sound on the porch and she finds Catra coming up the stairs in the darkness.
- “I thought you’d be asleep by now,” Catra says, and her words are a little slurred.
- “You sound disappointed.”
- Catra makes an unconfirming noise and hesitates before dropping down in the porch swing Adora is in. “Give me some blanket, I’m freezing.”

- “Maybe it’s those tiny shorts you’re wearing.”
- “Shut up, they’re comfortable. It’s harder to get sand out of pants.”
- “Uh huh, good excuse.”
- Catra laughs and bats her on the shoulder, but doesn’t say anything.
- They sit in silence for a few minutes, legs pressed against each other, looking out at the waves.
- “How did dinner with your mom go? You haven’t talked about it all day.”
- “Really well, actually. She cried.”
- “Good cry or bad cry?”
- “Depends on how you look at it.” Adora hesitates, sips at her hot chocolate. It’s cold now. “She said she failed me.”
- “Did she?”
- That was a big question. What was it really, to fail someone? Was she let down? Of course. Disappointed? Absolutely. But was her mom trying to make it up to her, in her own ridiculous, rich way? Yes.
- “I think so.”
- “You don’t sound sure.”
- Adora sighs into her hot chocolate. For a moment, Catra rests her hand on Adora’s, but it falls away. Adora watches it fall.
- “She wants to have dinner with us.”
- “Like, all of us?”
- “No. Like, me and my girlfriend.”
- She knows its fake. The word doesn’t mean anything. But it hangs in the air between them like a heavy weight.
- “Guess I’ll have to put on my Girlfriend Shoes again, then.”
- “Don’t sound so disappointed,” Adora scoffs, playfully.
- “I wouldn’t be.”
- Adora’s mind takes a minute to process the comment. Catra looks almost deadly serious. “What did you say?”
- “I wouldn’t be,” she repeats slowly, as if she’s only processing it herself. “Disappointed. I mean. To be your girlfriend.” Catra’s eyes dart away.
- “What are you saying?” Adora whispers. She tries to memorize the picture in front of her. The moonlight on Catra’s

skin. The winged eyeliner, smudged a little on one corner. A stray piece of glitter in her cheek from Adora's own makeup. They sat on the blade of a knife, and Adora knew if she tipped the wrong way, she wouldn't see this sight again.

- "You're so dense sometimes," Catra whispers. She meets Adora's eyes again and Adora can see the moment her eyes steel and she makes her decision. She doesn't process anything between that second and Catra's lips on her own. A breath escapes Adora, and she melts into her. Catra grips her like a lifeline, and Adora can feel the trembling of the hand on her elbow. Mindlessly, Adora pulls Catra's hand from her arm and links their fingers together. With her other hand, she tilts Catra's chin up. Just like at the club, Catra's breath hitches, and Adora doesn't give her a chance to catch it. She leans her back onto the swing and maneuvers above her. The alcohol swims in her head and her hand drifts down to Catra's thigh. She's too distracted by Catra's lips to look, but she knows the outline of Catra's tattoos as if she drew them herself.
- They get lost in the sauce
- A loud bang jolts Adora upright. Bow and Glimmer are making their way up the stairs, gripping onto each other and laughing. Glimmer is the first to catch sight of Adora and Catra in the very compromising position and Glimmer gasps, shouts out some drunken slur of "sorry, sorry, leaving, bye" and the two crash inside. The door slams shut behind them.
- "Do you think they're gonna hook up?" Catra asks innocently.
- Adora looks down at Catra, eyes wide, and a breath passes between them before they're both laughing. Adora drops her head to Catra's shoulder and they laugh for a minute. Catra's fingers drift up her exposed side (crop top) and Adora twitches. "Your fingers are so cold"
- "Yeah, I didn't want to say anything, but I'm fucking freezing"
- "Jesus, Catra, we're going inside."
- Adora starts to get up but Catra catches her by the shirt and pulls her in again for a long kiss. Then, she pushes her back, smiles at her, and says "Okay, now we can go."

- They hear some incriminating noises from Glimmer and Bow's room and say nothing about it, only grin at each other.
- They get ready for bed, sneaking glances at each other and laughing when they catch each other.
- Some conversation about girlfriends

Next morning

- Adora stands outside with a cup of coffee and a big smile on her face. Glimmer is the first to come out and she looks like hell, but immediately clocks the smile on her face. Adora gives Glimmer her cup of coffee.
- "Spill"
- Adora just smiles and Glimmer drops the cup of coffee and screams, and grabs Adora's hands and jumps around in circles. Adora is laughing and Glimmer is laughing and everything is great. Adora finally grabs her by the shoulders and stops her, and very seriously goes, "you and Bow?"
- Glimmer gets all cheeky and goes "well… you know…" and then Adora screams and theyre jumping around and everything is great and happy.
- Bow and Catra both make it to the door at the same time, thinking someone is dying, but Glimmer just pounces on Catra and drags her into a hug. Adora jumps on Bow. Catra practically hisses at Glimmer's hug.
- The excitement gets out of hand and then they're all sprinting toward the ocean. They jump into the water in their pajamas and everyone is splashing each other. Bow and Glimmer dick around in shallow water, Adora and Catra are jumping into the waves and dunking each other. Adora drags Catra out of the water like a drowned cat and kisses her, hard. They hold on to each other for a moment, and a wave takes them both down. They resurface to Glimmer cheering from the shore.
- "How do I look?" Adora laughs through her tangle of hair and Catra catches her hand.
- (They kiss - "I can do that now!")

Chapter End Notes

you've all been so lovely and your comments have made me so happy, thank you guys for following along :') again, i hope i can come back and actually finish this sometime. it has been so fun to write, but life is life

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!